

# MOOD IN SOCIETY

## SML QUARTERLY NEWSLETTER

### Welcome to the August edition of Mood in Society

Dear Readers,

These past few months we explored a few moods all with one common theme. A theme that quietly shapes our everyday lives: the spaces we inhabit and how they influence our sense of belonging, connection and wellbeing. From public parks and city streets to football fields and digital platforms, the places where we gather are more than physical settings, they shape how we interact, form relationships and experience society.

In this edition, we examine three interconnected moods. We begin by exploring how *safety and gender influence access to leisure and public spaces*. We then turn to the changing landscape of *youth dating, where shrinking third spaces and digital deception are reshaping how young people connect*. Finally, we reflect on *football as more than a game, considering its role as a powerful space for recreation, identity formation and masculine socialization*.

Although these topics may seem different, they are united by a common question: What makes a space truly safe, welcoming and meaningful for everyone?

As always, thank you for reading, sharing your perspectives and contributing to the conversations across the Mood in Society community. Your engagement continues to enrich these discussions and reminds us that understanding the social mood is a collective journey.

Editor Dr. Pumla Nofemele

